

Northern Pike

First to spawn, last to quit — Pine Lake & North Lake

Esox lucius



The Pike — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Tell it apart

Light bean-shaped spots on a dark green body — light-on-dark. The cheek is fully scaled and the lower half of the gill cover is bare. Five sensory pores along each side of the lower jaw.

Not a musky

A musky is the photographic negative: *dark* marks on a *light* body, the lower half of both the cheek and gill cover bare, and six to nine pores per side. At a 40 in minimum on musky and 26 in on pike, this matters.

Size here

20–30 in is the working range; 36 in and up is a real fish. State record 38 lb.

Spawn

The first gamefish to go, immediately after ice-out at 40–45 °F, in flooded marsh grass and shallow vegetation — often before the ice is fully gone from the main lake.

Season

J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
■			■		■		■		■		

Time of day

■			■		■		■		
Dawn			Mid		Dusk		Night		

Where

- Pine

Spots **1** and **9** in spring and fall, **5** along the deep weed edge in summer. In a lake this cold and clear, the largest pike go deep and cool in July and August — 25–40 ft on the edge of the basin, not in the shallows.
- North

Spots **2** (outlet), **5** (the neck) and **6** (river inlet). Current and weed. This lake fishes more like a classic pike water than Pine does.
- Cover

Weed edges, points, and any narrows. Pike are ambush hunters that want a wall at their back and open water in front.

How

- Big fish

A large sucker on a quick-strike rig under a float, *see the **quick-strike rig** sheet*. This is how most of the biggest pike in these lakes are taken.
- Ice

Tip-ups with a live shiner set just off the bottom along the weed edge, *see the **tip-up** sheet*.
- Leader

Always. A wire or heavy fluorocarbon leader. Pike teeth cut straight line, and losing a fish with a hook in it is a bad outcome for the fish, not just for you.

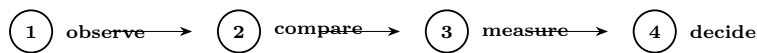
HANDLING A PIKE

The teeth are backward-facing and will cut you to the bone. Long pliers and jaw spreaders, always; fingers never go in the mouth or under the gill plate. Support a big fish horizontally with a wet hand under the belly. Above roughly 70 °F a released pike is fragile — unhook it in the net, in the water, and let it go.

Worth knowing

Built for one strike	A pike accelerates from rest at close to eight body lengths per second, using a body shape — fins bunched at the back, like the flights on a dart — optimised entirely for a single explosive lunge. It is a poor endurance swimmer, which is why it ambushes and does not chase far.
They eat things far too big	Pike routinely take prey a third to half their own length, including other pike. A 30 in fish will attack a 12 in one. This is why a bait most people think is absurdly large is often exactly right.
The big ones are all female	Female pike grow faster, live longer and reach far greater size. Every pike over about 34 in in these lakes is almost certainly a female, and killing them removes the fish producing the next generation.
Heat is their limit	Pike are a cool-water fish and become stressed above roughly 75 °F. In a clear deep lake like Pine they simply leave — the big ones go down to 25–40 ft in July, which is why the shallow weed edge produces only small ones in summer.
Spawn before the ice is gone	Pike move into flooded marsh grass at 40–45 °F, sometimes with ice still on the main lake. They are done spawning before a bass has thought about it.

Prove it in hand



Ask first	Are the spots light on dark, the tail lobes rounded, and five jaw pores present per side?
Rule out	Musky show dark marks on light ground, pointed tail lobes, and six to nine pores; pattern alone is insufficient.
Measure	Close the mouth, pinch the tail only if the rule says to, and read total length against a rigid board: wet the board, close the mouth, support the belly, and read before prolonged air exposure.
Field proof	Pattern, pores, and tail shape must all agree before harvest. Photograph the whole side profile and the decisive feature before release if the identification remains uncertain.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 26 in minimum, 2 per day, open 2 May–7 March. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR’s current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

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